Common Ground
Study companion

Evidence notes and an optional written transfer check. This introductory course uses fictional situations to help you explain everyday behavior, examine evidence, and practice applying ideas.

The chapter decks and recorded narration introduce the ideas. These additional notes distinguish general patterns from individual predictions. The written case has no recorded narration. Suggested answers follow the tasks; cover them until you have tried.

Evidence and limits

These are selected sources, not a systematic literature review. Some links provide an abstract rather than free full text. Open introductory readings remain linked in each deck.

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1. The person and the room

Goal: Given an ambiguous action, generate two situational explanations and identify evidence that distinguishes them from a personal explanation.

- Behavior can reflect personal tendencies, circumstances, and their interaction.
- Attribution biases describe tendencies rather than diagnoses of an individual.

A single late arrival cannot isolate character from circumstances. Use repeated observations and competing explanations; a bias label alone is not evidence.

- Gilbert & Malone (1995), The correspondence bias (https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/7870861/)
  Review; abstract available

2. The poster that “worked”

Goal: Identify a confound in a before-and-after claim and propose a fairer comparison.

- Random assignment improves comparisons between conditions; random sampling concerns who is selected.
- One before-and-after difference does not isolate a cause; replication and uncertainty matter.

Random assignment helps balance other causes on average. It does not guarantee equal groups, prevent spillover, or make a narrow sample representative. The 12-versus-15 example is hypothetical and does not establish a reliable effect.

- Open Science Collaboration (2015), Estimating the reproducibility of psychological science (https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/26315443/)
  Replication project; abstract available

3. The story that comes to mind

Goal: Identify a missing base rate and formulate a question that could challenge an initial belief.

- Accessible examples can influence frequency judgments.
- Representative records help distinguish a vivid impression from the underlying rate.

Heuristics can be useful. Diagnose a judgment by comparing it with relevant evidence, rather than assuming that an intuitive answer is biased. A complaint channel can identify faults without estimating their prevalence.

- Tversky & Kahneman (1973), Availability: A heuristic for judging frequency and probability (https://doi.org/10.1016/0010-0285(73)90033-9)
  Foundational experiments; access varies

4. The plan we cannot let go

Goal: Distinguish dissonance reduction from evidence-based revision and compare future options without counting irrecoverable costs as benefits.

- Dissonance is a theoretical framework; particular demonstrations need separate evaluation.
- Irrecoverable costs differ from future costs and benefits.

The 2024 multilab study did not support its primary high-choice versus low-choice attitude prediction. That result concerns the tested induced-compliance procedure; it does not settle every dissonance claim. Past investments can still matter through their future consequences.

- Vaidis et al. (2024), A Multilab Replication of the Induced-Compliance Paradigm of Cognitive Dissonance (https://www.psychologicalscience.org/journals/ampps/25152459231213375/)
  Preregistered multilab replication
- Arkes & Blumer (1985), The psychology of sunk cost (https://doi.org/10.1016/0749-5978(85)90049-4)
  Foundational experiments; access varies

5. The quiet vote

Goal: Distinguish normative and informational influence and design a process that makes independent concerns visible.

- Normative influence concerns acceptance; informational influence treats others as evidence.
- Conformity, compliance, and obedience depend on the setting and process.

The classic tasks used particular participants, procedures, and pressures. Their results should not be converted into a universal conformity or obedience rate. Independent judgments and stop rules are practical hypotheses to evaluate in a real group.

- Noba, Conformity and Obedience (https://nobaproject.com/modules/conformity-and-obedience)
  Open introductory module

6. The invitation

Goal: Evaluate a message by its evidence, audience needs, and honest description of social norms.

- Motivation and ability influence how much a message is examined.
- Descriptive and injunctive norms concern behavior and approval respectively.

Central and peripheral processing describe differences along an elaboration continuum. A cue can matter in more than one way depending on the decision. A click, an attitude report, informed participation, and sustained behavior are different outcomes.

- Elaboration Likelihood Model, Oxford reference entry (https://academic.oup.com/reference/62347/reference-article-abstract/554213168)
  Reference overview; access varies
- Cialdini, Reno & Kallgren (1990), A focus theory of normative conduct (https://doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.58.6.1015)
  Experimental social-norm research; access varies

7. When “we” takes over

Goal: Identify a plausible group process behind a failure and select a procedure that addresses it.

- Group polarization, social loafing, and coordination loss describe different processes.
- An unfinished task is insufficient evidence that people are loafing.

A poor decision does not establish groupthink, and poor output does not establish low effort. Identify an observable process before choosing a remedy. The café examples illustrate possible explanations rather than diagnosing real groups.

- Karau & Williams (1993), Social loafing: A meta-analytic review and theoretical integration (https://doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.65.4.681)
  Meta-analysis; access varies

8. The invisible doorway

Goal: Distinguish stereotypes, prejudice, and discrimination and locate a procedural barrier to access.

- Stereotypes, prejudice, and discrimination are distinct, related concepts.
- Contact interventions and procedural changes need outcome-based evaluation.

Contact is not a universal remedy. The 2019 review found important gaps in randomized evidence for particular adult prejudice outcomes; the 2021 review also highlights limits in durability and generalization. Evaluate the actual population, setting, access, behavior, and follow-up. A single implicit-association score is not a character diagnosis.

- Paluck, Green & Green (2019), The contact hypothesis re-evaluated (https://www.cambridge.org/core/journals/behavioural-public-policy/article/contact-hypothesis-reevaluated/142C913E7FA9E121277B29E994124EC5)
  Review of randomized contact evidence
- Paluck et al. (2021), Prejudice Reduction: Progress and Challenges (https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/32928061/)
  Review of intervention experiments; abstract available

9. A place beside someone

Goal: Explain how contact opportunities and reciprocal responsiveness can support closeness without guaranteeing it.

- Opportunity, familiarity, and similarity can be associated with liking and connection.
- Disclosure and perceived responsiveness can contribute to experienced intimacy.

Repeated exposure is not an unlimited rule that more contact produces more liking. Meta-analytic patterns vary with conditions and can be nonlinear. Relationship associations do not establish a guaranteed intervention, and they never override a person's boundary.

- Montoya et al. (2017), A re-examination of the mere exposure effect (https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/28263645/)
  Meta-analysis; abstract available
- Laurenceau, Barrett & Pietromonaco (1998), Intimacy as an interpersonal process (https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/9599440/)
  Interpersonal-process studies; abstract available

10. Who will do something?

Goal: Identify barriers to helping and design a specific, safe response with clear responsibility.

- Bystander effects depend on danger, relationships, and available support.
- Aggression measures and helping plans require careful interpretation.

Other people can reduce an individual's likelihood of helping in some settings and provide essential support in others. A crowd is not a deterministic cause of inaction. Social-psychology models do not replace emergency training, and laboratory aggression measures are imperfect indicators of serious violence.

- Fischer et al. (2011), The bystander-effect: a meta-analytic review (https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/21534650/)
  Meta-analysis; abstract available

Try a new case

Work without your notes first. Allow about 20–30 minutes. Write your reasoning somewhere private; this page does not collect or grade it. The case is fictional, and different well-supported plans can be reasonable.

The language club

An online language club changes its reminder message. Attendance rises from 14 of 20 members one week to 17 of 20 the next. That second week also has a different lesson topic and a school holiday. The organizer credits the new message.

The organizer opens a planning call by recommending daily homework. Two members agree; others remain quiet. One quiet member privately worries about the workload and assumes everyone else wants the plan. Another member's late arrivals are described as poor commitment before anyone asks about their work schedule.

The club has already paid a nonrefundable fee for a learning app. Some members want to keep using it because of that payment, although a free alternative may meet their future needs. The organizer also worries that switching would make their earlier judgment look poor. Recruitment mainly happens through existing friends. A proposed invitation says that everyone practices daily, but the club has no evidence for that claim.

A newcomer shares a personal difficulty. A member offers advice immediately without asking what support is wanted. Later, a shared resource list remains unfinished because each person assumed someone else was responsible.

Write your reasoning

1. **Separate observations from explanations**

   Identify two observations and two interpretations. Give a plausible alternative to one interpretation, and name evidence that would help distinguish the explanations. What records would you need before judging how common late arrivals are?

2. **Test a causal claim**

   Design a fairer test of the reminder. Specify the allocation, outcome, likely spillover, and what a small observed difference would leave uncertain. Who would the result represent?

3. **Explain the group decision**

   Distinguish two reasons a member might publicly agree. Choose a procedure that makes independent concerns visible, and explain why an unfinished task does not establish loafing.

4. **Compare future options**

   Explain how the app payment should enter the decision. Identify at least two future consequences that still matter. Distinguish defending an earlier judgment from counting money that cannot be recovered.

5. **Design an honest, accessible invitation**

   Revise the unsupported daily-practice claim and one access barrier. Specify an outcome you would examine afterward. What would the observed recruitment barrier establish about prejudice?

6. **Support connection and constructive action**

   Respond to the newcomer while respecting their choice, then give a low-risk helping plan for the resource list. State one limit of your explanation.

Suggested reasoning

1. Separate observations from explanations

Attendance counts and late arrivals are observations. Crediting the reminder or inferring poor commitment are interpretations. Lesson interest, the holiday, or a work constraint are alternatives. Comparable attendance records or a respectful question about availability could help distinguish them. Estimating lateness also requires a consistent definition and a record of all comparable arrivals, including those on time; a few memorable late arrivals do not supply a rate.

Revisit chapters 1, 3.

2. Test a causal claim

For the same events, randomly allocate comparable members to invitation versions, keep practical details consistent, define attendance in advance, and account for messages being shared. Estimate the difference and its uncertainty. A small or imprecise result would not prove either a useful effect or exactly no effect. The result would initially concern the tested members, messages, and events; random allocation does not create a representative population sample.

Revisit chapters 2.

3. Explain the group decision

A member may seek acceptance or treat others' responses as information. Collect independent judgments before public discussion and review contrary evidence. The resource list could reflect unclear ownership, dependencies, or missing tools even when effort is genuine.

Revisit chapters 5, 7.

4. Compare future options

The nonrefundable payment is sunk under the case assumptions. Compare future time, support, switching costs, accessibility, reliability, and learning benefits. Keeping the paid app can be reasonable if its future advantages justify it; switching is not automatically the correct answer. Defending an earlier judgment may reduce discomfort about inconsistency; treating the nonrefundable fee as a reason to continue is the distinct sunk-cost problem.

Revisit chapters 4.

5. Design an honest, accessible invitation

State a concrete, truthful commitment and available support, with room to decline. Open recruitment beyond existing friends and examine relevant requirements or scheduling barriers. Track who can apply, participate, and remain involved, while protecting privacy. Feeling inclusive or getting clicks is insufficient on its own. A recruitment rule can restrict access without an openly hostile statement. Its consequences do not, alone, establish an organizer's attitude or diagnose the organizer's character.

Revisit chapters 6, 8.

6. Support connection and constructive action

Ask whether the newcomer wants listening, practical help, or advice, and accept the response. Agree on a named owner, a specific next action, support, and feedback for the resource list. General relationship or bystander patterns cannot diagnose an individual's motives or guarantee the plan's success.

Revisit chapters 9, 10.

Assess your explanation

Concept and mechanism

Stronger: Names a relevant concept and explains how it could operate in this case, including a competing explanation.

Needs development: Names a concept but gives little explanation or treats a label as a diagnosis.

Evidence and uncertainty

Stronger: Separates observation from inference, proposes discriminating evidence, and states what remains uncertain.

Needs development: Treats the before-and-after change or a single behavior as proof.

Action and evaluation

Stronger: Proposes a specific feasible action, explains the mechanism, and identifies a meaningful outcome and follow-up.

Needs development: Offers a general appeal without identifying responsibility, comparison, or outcome.

Limits and autonomy

Stronger: Uses conditional language, respects stated boundaries, and identifies at least one limit on generalization.

Needs development: Treats an average pattern as a guarantee or overrides a person's expressed wishes.

After comparing your work with the suggested reasoning, revise one weak answer in your own words. Revisit the case in about a week using a different setting. This self-check can expose gaps; it does not certify mastery or demonstrate real-world transfer.